dia. Karnavat sees an opportunity in consumers' interest in products and services that originate in their own country or hometown, and in the pride that can accompany that connection. Understanding what Indian consumers want is a significant opportunity for homegrown businesses, he says.

But he cautions against making craftsmanship and storytelling the answer to every challenge. Both need to be balanced with innovation, price competitiveness and customer service, he says.

Gupta sees the management layer as a critical constraint in the development of Indian luxury businesses. He identifies opportunities in craft management, product development, brand management, international distribution, and business development. These roles can translate craftsmanship into repeatable product categories and take design-led businesses into new markets.

For young professionals, this means that an interest in fashion or design is only one possible entry point. Understanding the commercial and operational side of a brand can be equally important.

CUSTOMER ENGAGEMENT

Another area where the demands of luxury become particularly visible is buyer experience. Karnavat believes the product business has much to learn from hospitality, where service is treated as an essential part of the offering rather than an additional feature. Luxury businesses need to develop customer service and bring hospitality into the way they sell and deliver products.

That calls for human skills as well as technical knowledge. Patience is another quality, he emphasises.

For luxury businesses, the challenge is to ensure that the experience matches the promise made by the brand. For employees, it is to understand how their decisions, communication and attention to detail contribute to that experience.

LEARNING THE BUSINESS

As the range of luxury careers expands, specialised education is one route through which students can build the necessary understanding. But the value of a programme depends on whether it prepares students for the commercial realities of the industry, rather than simply introducing them to prominent brands.

Jain says the aim is to prepare students for the industry, as it is likely to evolve, rather than merely reflect current practices. "Our students need to be trained to think about where the industry will be three years from now and prepare for that standard today," he says.

S. P. Jain School of Global Management offers a Global Luxury Goods & Services Management programme. Students spend the first six months in Mumbai building foundations in general management, including strategy, marketing, finance, and operations. The next six months in Milan apply those tools to luxury, covering areas such as brand strategy, retail, customer experience and innovation.

Tedaldi says students learn from academics, industry professionals and consultants, while also experiencing luxury businesses in their operating environments. The programme includes study tours in France, Switzerland, and Italy's Emilia-Romagna region, exposing students to areas including haute couture, perfumery, watchmaking, hospitality, automobiles, and food.

"An MBA teaches you to manage a business. It rarely teaches you why a Swiss watch, a bottle of champagne or a Pagani is worth what it is," says

WHAT IT TAKES

- LUXURY CAREERS EXTEND FAR BEYOND FASHION AND DESIGN
- IN LUXURY, THE EXPERIENCE IS AS IMPORTANT AS THE PRODUCT
- THE TALENT GAP LIES IN JUDGEMENT, SERVICE, AND SPECIALISED SKILLS
- INDIAN CRAFTSMANSHIP NEEDS STRONGER BRANDS AND BUSINESS LEADERSHIP
- PRACTICAL EXPERIENCE IS KEY TO BUILDING A CAREER IN LUXURY